

AI Memory Stack

Installation Checklist — from blank machine to a running local AI · v3.0

How to use this: print it, keep it next to the machine, tick every box in order. Fill in the blanks as you go — usernames, hostnames, wifi — so everything is in one place. Never skip ahead: each block builds on the previous one.

Passwords: a password manager (Bitwarden, 1Password, KeePassXC) is the first choice. The lines below say "password or hint — your choice". Be aware: filled in, this sheet is a complete access kit to the machine (passwords + IP + username on one page). Lock it away. Shred it on disposal. Never photograph it.

Step 0 — Pick a machine (5 min)

Windows is supported via WSL2 only (the script prints exact instructions if you run it there). For a clean local-first install, macOS or Linux Mint is simpler.

RAM	What you can run
8 GB (minimum)	3B models — works, but limited quality
16 GB	7–14B models — good daily assistant
32–48 GB (recommended)	32–35B models — strong local agent

Also needed: 60+ GB free disk (20 GB absolute minimum), internet for the install.

■ I am installing on: ■ Mac ■ PC with Linux Mint

Machine name / location: _____

Tip: start with ONE machine. The second install takes 15 minutes with this same list.

Track A — Mac: clean reinstall (45–60 min)

Skip to Track B if you chose Linux Mint.

A1. Enter Recovery Mode — depends on your Mac's chip

- Back up anything you want to keep (external drive or another machine)
- Find your chip type: → About This Mac. Tick one: ■ Apple Silicon (M1–M4) ■ Intel
- **Apple Silicon:** shut down fully → press and HOLD the power button until 'Loading startup options' → Options → Continue
- **Intel:** shut down → press power, then immediately hold **Cmd+R** until the Apple logo appears

A2. Erase and reinstall macOS

- Disk Utility → select 'Macintosh HD' → Erase (format: APFS) → quit Disk Utility
- Reinstall macOS → follow the wizard (20–40 min, several restarts)

A3. First-run setup — WITHOUT cloud

- Language / country / keyboard → connect to wifi

Wifi network: _____

- At 'Sign in with your Apple ID': choose **Set Up Later / Skip** — macOS requires NO account
- Create the local computer account:

Full name: _____

Account name (short, lowercase): _____

Password or hint (your choice — see warning, p.1): _____

- Decline: Siri analytics, usage data sharing, Screen Time (all can be enabled later)
- FileVault (disk encryption): recommended if theft is a risk. If enabled, store the recovery key in your password manager
- On the desktop: run Software Update (→ System Settings → General → Software Update)
- **Power settings (do this NOW — sleep kills downloads and remote access):** System Settings → search 'sleep' → prevent sleeping when display is off / set sleep to Never. Screen turning off is fine — system sleep is not
- Open **Terminal** (Cmd+Space, type 'terminal', Enter) → go to **Step 2** on page 4

On Mac the script will pause and tell you exactly which security popup to expect (Xcode tools ~5–8 min, 'ollama was blocked', firewall). That is normal — it waits for you. The script itself never asks for your password on macOS.

Track B — Linux Mint on a PC (60–90 min)

B1. Create the USB installer (on any working computer)

- Download Linux Mint 22 'Cinnamon' ISO from linuxmint.com/download.php
- Download **balenaEtcher** (etcher.balena.io)
- Insert a USB stick (8 GB+ — **everything on it is erased**)
- Etcher: pick the ISO → pick the stick → Flash (5–10 min)

B2. Boot the PC from the stick

- Insert stick, power on, immediately tap the boot-menu key repeatedly:
Common: **F12** (Dell/Lenovo) · **F9** (HP) · **F8/F11** (Asus/MSI) · **Esc** (older)

My PC's boot key turned out to be: _____

- Pick the USB stick → 'Start Linux Mint'
- If it refuses: enter BIOS (**Del** or **F2**) → disable 'Secure Boot' → retry

B3. Install

- Double-click **Install Linux Mint** on the desktop
- Language / keyboard → tick 'Install multimedia codecs'
- Installation type: **Erase disk and install Mint** (if the PC is dedicated)
- Encryption (LVM + encrypt): recommended if theft is a risk — store the passphrase in your password manager (asked at EVERY boot)
- Create the user:

Your name: _____

Computer name (hostname): _____

Username (lowercase): _____

Password or hint (your choice — see warning, p.1): _____

- Install (15–25 min) → restart → remove the stick when asked

B4. After first login

- Update Manager (shield icon) → install ALL updates → restart
- **Power settings (NOW):** Menu → Power Management → set 'suspend when inactive' to Never. Screen blanking is fine — system suspend is not
- **Old PC?** If the BIOS clock was wrong or settings were forgotten: replace the CMOS battery (CR2032, ~2 €) — a dead one also forgets the power setting below
- **BIOS 'Restore on AC Power Loss':** reboot → enter BIOS (Del/F2) → Power settings → set to **Power On** (makes the PC boot by itself after an outage)
- Open **Terminal** (Ctrl+Alt+T) → go to **Step 2**

On Linux the script asks for your login password ONCE at the start ('sudo') to install system packages. That is the only time. Never start the script itself with sudo.

Step 2 — The AI layer (same for Mac and Linux)

Three scripts, run in order. They handle the classic beginner traps (PATH, sudo, dependencies, interruptions) — your job is: run, read, tick.

2.1 Get the scripts and start — exactly like this

- In the machine's web browser, open the project page (github.com/jordglob/local-ai-memory) → green **Code** button → **Download ZIP**. It lands in **Downloads**
- Double-click the ZIP in Downloads so a folder appears (macOS does this automatically)
- In the terminal, go to that folder: **cd ~/Downloads/local-ai-memory-main** (*cd = change directory; press Tab to auto-complete the name*)
- Sanity check — type: **ls ai-memory-*.sh** You should see the script files listed. If 'No such file or directory': you are in the wrong folder — run the cd line again

The installer copies all scripts to a permanent home (~/.Documents/ai-memory/.tools/) — after step 2.2 you can delete the download and every later command uses that path.

2.2 Install (15–25 min; Intel Mac 25–35; slow internet adds 10–20)

- In the terminal: **bash ai-memory-setup.sh**
- Linux: type your password ONCE when asked (sudo)
- Mac: approve the popups when the script pauses and points at them
- Answer the two questions: install Hermes Agent? · start Ollama at login? (Enter = yes)
- Wait for the green box: **'Installation complete — no errors'**
- If RED: read the last line, fix, run the same command again — it resumes where it stopped

Done — date/time: _____

2.3 Configure (5–10 min + optional model download)

- Open a NEW terminal window (Cmd+N / Ctrl+Shift+N)
- Run: **bash ~/.Documents/ai-memory/.tools/ai-memory-configure.sh**
- It analyzes your hardware and suggests the best model — Enter to accept
- If it offers a download: **y** (a 35B model is ~20 GB; 30+ min on slow lines)
- API keys: just press **Enter** twice to skip — everything runs locally anyway

Selected model: _____

2.4 Import your history (5–15 min)

- Order your exports first (each takes minutes to arrive by email):
Claude: [claude.ai](#) → Settings → Privacy → Export Data · ChatGPT: Settings → Data Controls → Export
- Put the downloaded ZIP(s) in this machine's Downloads folder
- Run: **bash ~/.Documents/ai-memory/.tools/ai-memory-ingest.sh** — it finds exports and local tool histories itself and asks before importing
- 10 sources supported — see them all with **--list-sources**

Conversations imported: _____

2.5 First run — the test

- Run: **hermes chat** (or: **bash ~/.Documents/ai-memory/.tools/resume.sh**)
- Ask about something from your imported history — verify it can find it
- DONE. File this checklist (locked away) or shred it

Machine identity (the install script prints these values — just copy)

Hostname: _____

Local IP: _____

SSH line (ssh user@ip): _____

Tailscale IP/name (if used): _____

RustDesk ID (if used): _____

Headless node (optional) — reach this machine without a screen

Run this AFTER Step 2, while you still have a screen and keyboard connected. It is the last time you need them.

- Run: **bash ~/Documents/ai-memory/.tools/ai-memory-remote.sh**
- Part 1–2: it enables SSH and installs your public key (easiest: from `github.com/<your-user>.keys`)
- Part 3: verify key login FROM YOUR OTHER COMPUTER before letting it disable password login
- Part 4–5 (optional): Tailscale for access from anywhere · RustDesk for the graphical moments (macOS popups)
- Part 6: always-on power profile (no sleep, auto-restart after power loss)
- Mac only: HDMI **dummy plug** (~10 €) in a video port — without it remote graphics is slow and blurry
- Mac only: enable autologin (System Settings → Users & Groups) so services return after a reboot — requires FileVault OFF (tradeoff on the Tips page)
- **MANDATORY pull-the-plug test:** shut down → pull the cord → wait 1 min → plug in. The machine must boot and answer SSH by itself. PCs: fix in BIOS if not. Apple Silicon minis: known to sometimes ignore the setting — if so, plan for a physical button press after outages
- Always keep TWO ways in (SSH + one graphical) — an update can break either one

Tips & Tricks (after everything works)

cmux — run several AI agents side by side (macOS)

A native, open-source terminal built on Ghostty's renderer, designed for agent work: a vertical sidebar shows each workspace's git branch and latest notification, and a panel lights up when an agent needs your input. Free, no telemetry, no account. Install AFTER the base setup works: download from **cmux.io** or GitHub (sst/cmux). Linux alternative: Ghostty (same engine, without the agent features) or plain tmux.

Syncthing — sync the vault between machines, no cloud

Free, peer-to-peer, encrypted. Install on both machines (**syncthing.net**), share the vault folder (~/.Documents/ai-memory). Your conversations never touch a third-party server. Do NOT sync ~/.hermes between machines — agent state is per-machine.

Backups — two things matter

1) The vault (~/.Documents/ai-memory) — plain files, any backup tool works; even a periodic copy to a USB drive is fine. 2) ~/.hermes — the agent's memory and config. Time Machine (Mac) or Timeshift+home backup (Mint) covers both. Test a restore once.

Update Advisor — built in

The agent's workspace instructions include a read-only update check: ask it to 'check for updates' and it writes a report with exact upgrade commands to 00-Inbox/UPDATES.md. It never upgrades anything by itself — you decide.

Disk encryption (FileVault / LUKS) — an honest tradeoff

On a laptop that leaves the house: enable it (theft protection). On a headless always-on node: it blocks unattended reboots — the machine stops at a pre-boot password screen no remote tool can reach. Pick based on where the machine lives. If your router ever hands out new IPs, set a DHCP reservation for each node so the identity block stays true. Prefer zero cloud? Plain WireGuard replaces Tailscale at the cost of manual key setup.

If something gets stuck

1) Read the last red line — the scripts always say WHAT failed and what to do. 2) Re-run the same command — everything resumes where it stopped. 3) The log lives at ~/.Documents/ai-memory/.tools/setup.log — show it to an AI assistant and troubleshoot together. 4) Nothing in these steps can break the computer — worst case is restarting from Step 2.